VUGA NDAKUMVA | GBV EDUCATIONAL CONTENT SERIES

CHAPTER 09

Technology-Facilitated and Online Gender-Based Violence

Understanding digital abuse, recognizing warning signs, protecting safety, and accessing respectful support

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Intended audience: adults, older adolescents with age-appropriate support, educators, community advocates, and first-line service providers.

This chapter does not request private experiences or personal information. All scenarios are fictional and are not reports of actual individuals.

Learning goals and how to use this chapter

By the end of this chapter, readers should be able to define technology-facilitated gender-based violence (TFGBV), identify several forms of digital abuse, understand the relationship between online and offline threats, consider safer responses, and know where to seek support in Rwanda. A reader need not have experienced violence to benefit from the material.

An essential starting point
Digital abuse is real abuse. The responsibility for harassment, coercion, stalking, or non-consensual sharing rests with the person committing it. Technology safety steps are choices, not obligations or guarantees. If someone might be monitoring a device or account, an abrupt security change could increase danger.

01 | What is technology-facilitated GBV?

Technology-facilitated gender-based violence is a harmful act that is committed, enabled, intensified, or spread through information and communication technology and connected to gender-based targeting or power inequalities. It can cause psychological, sexual, social, economic, political, or physical harm. It may occur through phones, messages, social media, email, shared cloud accounts, smart devices, gaming platforms, or location tools. [1, 2]

The word "online" captures only part of the problem. A person may be monitored through location settings, harassed by telephone, tracked through shared accounts, or threatened with the release of private information. Digital harm can cross into offline life when a location is exposed, an employer is contacted, or threats create fear of physical assault.

Not every rude online comment is necessarily GBV. Context matters: discriminatory targeting, sexualized threats, controlling behavior, repeated harassment, and misuse of power can signal gender-based abuse. Even where a single act is not clearly categorized as GBV, it may still be harmful and merit support.

02 | How digital abuse differs from ordinary disagreement

Disagreement involves expressing a different view. Abuse uses intimidation, non-consensual exposure, threats, deception, repeated unwanted contact, or coercion to cause harm or restrict another person's freedom. The affected person does not need to prove a repeated pattern before a serious threat or non-consensual intimate-image disclosure is taken seriously.

The scale and speed of digital distribution can multiply harm: material can be copied rapidly, resurface after removal, be shared anonymously, or reach workplaces and families. Yet digital risks should not be presented as unavoidable; platforms, schools, employers, public institutions and other actors have responsibilities to prevent and respond.

03 | Major forms of technology-facilitated abuse

Online harassment and gendered hate

Repeated insulting, sexualized, degrading, or threatening messages, including coordinated attacks intended to shame or silence a person. A single credible threat is serious even without repetition.

Cyberstalking and unwanted monitoring

Persistent unwanted messages, tracking, repeated account contact, checking whereabouts, or using shared digital services to monitor someone. It may accompany intimate partner violence.

Non-consensual intimate-image abuse

Sharing, threatening to share, or creating intimate images without the person's agreement, including AI-generated or manipulated material. Prior consensual creation or sharing with one person never means consent to redistribution.

Doxing and exposure of private information

Publishing a home address, telephone number, private correspondence, or identifying details to expose someone to threats, harassment, or loss of safety.

Impersonation and account misuse

Creating a false profile, pretending to be someone else, accessing their accounts without authorization, or posting messages in their name to intimidate, defraud, or damage relationships.

Digital sexual coercion and extortion

Demanding sexual images, sexual acts, money, or compliance by threatening to release private material or harm someone. A survivor is not responsible for the threat.

Location and device surveillance

Using shared accounts, connected devices, permissions, location services, or potentially malicious tools to track movements or communications without informed agreement.

Economic and professional sabotage

Restricting access to mobile money, digital work platforms or education accounts; contacting employers with threats; or using account control to interfere with income or study.

04 | Why forms of abuse overlap

A former partner might monitor a shared cloud account, send threats, impersonate a survivor online, and contact their workplace. The harm is not only "a password problem" or "a social media problem"; it may be part of broader coercive control. Responses should consider immediate safety, relationships of power, technology access, the survivor's preferences, and available support.

05 | The role of artificial intelligence

AI tools can be misused to create fabricated intimate images, impersonate voices, produce believable forged messages, or amplify targeted abuse. A manipulated image is not proof that an event occurred. If a person is targeted, responders should avoid sharing the material further, blaming the survivor, or making promises that removal from the internet will be complete. [1, 3]

Prevention also requires platforms and institutions to address reporting failures, abusive content dissemination, privacy weaknesses, and harmful design practices. The burden should not be placed entirely on the targeted person.

06 | Risk factors and unequal exposure

Women and girls are disproportionately exposed to many forms of technology-facilitated violence; public-facing women, journalists, women in leadership, and people experiencing discrimination can face targeted attacks. Children and adolescents have distinct developmental and protection needs. Individuals with disabilities or limited digital access may face extra obstacles to safe reporting. [1, 2]

Risk factors do not predict who will be abused and do not excuse perpetrators. A person should never be blamed for using social media, posting photographs, entering a relationship, trusting somebody, or having limited technical knowledge.

07 | Signs that digital behavior is becoming unsafe

- Repeated unwanted contact after a clear request to stop, especially when it moves across platforms.
- Threats to publish intimate images, private conversations, location details, or accusations.
- Sudden account activity, password reset messages, unexpected devices, or unexplained sharing settings.
- Pressure to give passwords, share live location, respond immediately, or stop contacting friends.
- Attempts to control access to study accounts, work platforms, money or communication.
- Fear that online behavior could lead to physical confrontation, school exclusion, or job loss.

These signs are not proof of surveillance or wrongdoing by a particular person. Some account anomalies have ordinary technical explanations. Seek knowledgeable assistance without making risky assumptions or confronting a suspected abuser.

08 | Impact on wellbeing, rights and participation

Digital abuse may cause fear, sleep problems, shame, anxiety, concentration difficulties, social isolation, or avoidance of digital spaces. It can also disrupt school, work, income, relationships, and civic participation. These responses are understandable and vary by person. No one should need to provide intimate details in order to receive empathy and basic information.

Some people experience threats to physical safety, particularly when location details are disclosed or an abusive person has access to devices. Psychological support and digital-security assistance can complement, rather than replace, appropriate medical, legal, or protection services.

09 | First response: safety before technology

If someone discloses digital abuse, ask whether it is safe to discuss the issue on the current device or channel. Listen calmly, avoid requesting screenshots or intimate images, and ask what the person wants help with. Do not pressure them to report, block, change a password, or confront someone immediately. They may be using a monitored device. [4]

Safer response sequence
1. Check immediate physical and communication safety. 2. Ask what support is wanted. 3. Consider whether accounts/devices may be monitored. 4. Discuss practical options without imposing them. 5. Offer verified GBV, legal, protection or cybersecurity support. 6. Record only information necessary for a safe referral.

10 | Privacy and account-security options

Where it is safe, a trusted specialist may help review account recovery information, active sessions, login alerts, privacy and sharing permissions, connected devices, cloud photo synchronization, location sharing, and two-factor authentication. Separate accounts and unique passwords can reduce some risks, but changing them may notify another person or lock the survivor out of essential services.

When technology may be monitored, using a separate trusted device or seeking discreet specialist support can be safer than investigating the suspected device. Avoid installing unknown "anti-spyware" products or attempting to hack another account. Technical checks should be informed by consent, professional competence, and local law.

11 | Evidence and incident documentation

If safe and desired, documenting dates, platforms, usernames, links, messages and threats may help a report. Evidence can be stored through a trusted, secure method, but creating or retaining files may also expose someone if their device is monitored. A survivor can ask a qualified provider how to document material without causing additional harm.

Do not forward intimate content in group chats or to VUGA NDAKUMVA staff simply to "prove" a case. Where a child may be depicted in sexual content, do not download, copy, or redistribute it; seek prompt advice from child protection or law enforcement channels on how to report the content safely.

12 | Blocking, reporting and removing content

Platforms may offer blocking, muting, account-reporting, impersonation reporting, and requests to remove private or intimate content. These tools may reduce exposure but do not guarantee removal or safety. Blocking or reporting can sometimes trigger retaliation; consider timing and safety before acting. Avoid communicating directly with an extortionist without specialist advice.

If a person is being blackmailed, remind them they did not cause the abuse. Paying money or providing further material does not reliably end extortion. Specialist support can help identify safer

next actions.

13 | Responding to children and adolescents

Online grooming, sexual extortion, image-based abuse, and harassment involving children require age-appropriate safeguarding. Adults should respond without blame, use developmentally appropriate language, and avoid unnecessary repeated questioning. Confidentiality limits and mandatory reporting duties must be explained in a manner appropriate to the child and local law. [2]

A child should not be asked to negotiate with a suspected perpetrator. If there is imminent danger or sexual exploitation, contact an appropriate protection or emergency service. School staff should follow vetted safeguarding protocols rather than handling the matter through informal public discussion.

14 | What families, schools and workplaces can do

Prevention includes clear rules against harassment; private and accessible reporting pathways; trained focal points; proportional institutional responses; digital literacy; and policies that protect survivors against retaliation. Staff should not force a survivor to confront an alleged perpetrator or expose private evidence publicly.

Families can normalize asking permission before sharing photos and discussing account privacy without using fear. Schools can teach respectful digital communication and enable confidential referrals. Employers can protect work credentials and document harassment without punishing the person experiencing it.

15 | Rwanda: where to seek support

Rwanda's Isange One Stop Centres provide integrated GBV-related services. RIB publishes the following contacts: 3029 for Isange One Stop Centre, 3512 for domestic and gender-based violence reporting, 116 for child abuse, and 166 for emergencies or crime-related information. These are published contacts, not a guarantee that every digital complaint can be handled through every line. [5, 6]

UNHCR Rwanda notes that approaching an Isange Centre may lead to law-enforcement reporting. Where privacy or reporting obligations could affect safety, ask service providers to explain confidentiality limits and available options before disclosing sensitive details. For urgent physical danger, use emergency assistance and consider a safe location rather than relying only on online platform reports. [6]

Rwanda referral note
RIB: 166 (emergency / crime information), 3512 (GBV), 116 (child abuse). Isange One Stop Centre: 3029. Source: official RIB contact page and UNHCR Rwanda. Verify contact details and accessibility before operational publication.

16 | Five fictional Rwanda-relevant learning scenarios

Case 1 - Campus group harassment

Situation: A university student is mocked with sexualized comments across class chat groups. Others repost screenshots to embarrass her.

Learning points: The harm can involve gendered harassment and amplification. A response should prioritize the student's choices, school safeguarding channel, platform reporting options and safe documentation. Do not publicly repeat offensive material.

Case 2 - Shared location after a breakup

Situation: A former partner appears to know where a young adult is traveling and sends alarming messages. They previously shared a cloud account.

Learning points: Do not assume the technical cause. First assess physical safety and whether the current phone is safe. A qualified person can help examine account and location-sharing settings when doing so is safe.

Case 3 - A manipulated image

Situation: An employee learns that an altered intimate-looking image using her face is circulating in a workplace messaging group.

Learning points: The image does not establish consent or real conduct. Workplace response should protect privacy, stop redistribution, provide confidential reporting and avoid punishing the target.

Case 4 - Mobile money and account control

Situation: A person's partner insists on access to phone, wallet PIN and transaction notifications, then threatens to cut off household support.

Learning points: The concern may involve digital and economic coercive control. A survivor-centred plan should consider financial dependence, risk of retaliation and specialist support before changing access.

Case 5 - Child targeted through gaming chat

Situation: A teenager receives threats that private photos will be circulated unless they send more images.

Learning points: This is an urgent safeguarding concern. Avoid blame or negotiating with the threatening person. Support the child in accessing trusted safeguarding and appropriate reporting services; do not circulate images.

17 | Five guided learning activities

Activity A - Recognize the behavior

Task: Read the five cases and identify whether harassment, stalking, extortion, impersonation, or economic control may be present. It is acceptable to identify more than one form.

Facilitator guidance: Possible answer: Case 1 harassment; Case 2 possible stalking/monitoring; Case 3 image-based abuse; Case 4 digital-economic coercion; Case 5 sexual extortion and child safeguarding.

Activity B - Safe communication check

Task: Imagine a friend says their partner reads their messages. List two questions you might ask before sending advice or resources.

Facilitator guidance: Suggested answer: "Is it safe for us to communicate here?" and "Would you prefer another time or safer channel?" Do not ask for proof or demand disclosure.

Activity C - Consent and image sharing

Task: Discuss whether consent to take or privately send a photo also means permission to forward it to classmates or colleagues.

Facilitator guidance: Suggested answer: No. Consent is specific; sharing with one person is not agreement for further distribution.

Activity D - Institutional response

Task: Imagine a school receives a report of repeated gendered harassment. Identify three supportive institutional actions.

Facilitator guidance: Suggested answer: confidential intake, protection against retaliation, and referral to a trained safeguarding focal point; plus appropriate platform/evidence procedures.

Activity E - Optional safety reflection

Task: Without writing personal passwords, account names or experiences, identify one trusted professional or service that could help with digital abuse.

Facilitator guidance: There is no single correct answer. Avoid recording sensitive details in a device or notebook if it could be accessed by someone else.

18 | Knowledge assessment - 10 questions

1. Can technology-facilitated GBV occur without social media?

Answer: Yes. Calls, shared accounts, location systems and other technologies can be involved.

2. Does agreeing to a private photo mean agreeing to public distribution?

Answer: No. Consent to one use does not authorize another use.

3. Is every disagreement in a group chat automatically GBV?

Answer: No. Context, conduct, and gender-based targeting matter.

4. What should come before changing passwords on a suspected monitored device?

Answer: A safety assessment, including possible retaliation or account alerts.

5. Should a responder request intimate images as proof?

Answer: No. Avoid collecting or spreading unnecessary sensitive material.

6. Can digital threats lead to offline danger?

Answer: Yes. Exposure of location or identity and coercive control can create offline risks.

7. Is a fabricated AI image proof a person engaged in that depicted activity?

Answer: No. Manipulated content is not reliable evidence of actual conduct.

8. Should a child be told to negotiate with an online extortionist?

Answer: No. Escalate via safe child-protection channels.

9. Is reporting or blocking always risk-free?

Answer: No. These may be useful options but could alert an abuser.

10. Who is responsible for digital abuse?

Answer: The person committing it, not the survivor.

19 | Glossary

TFGBV: Technology-facilitated gender-based violence.

Cyberstalking: Repeated unwanted following, contact or monitoring facilitated by technology.

Doxing: Revealing private or identifying information without authorization, often to expose someone to harm.

Image-based abuse: Non-consensual creation, sharing or threatening to share intimate imagery, including manipulated images.

Impersonation: Pretending to be another person online to mislead or harm others.

Digital coercive control: Using digital access, communications or monitoring to restrict a person's freedom.

Safeguarding: Actions and responsibilities intended to prevent and respond to harm, especially involving children or vulnerable people.

Two-factor authentication: An additional verification step to access an account; useful but must be deployed safely.

20 | Key lessons and further support

- Digital and offline forms of violence can reinforce each other.
- Privacy, dignity and consent apply to images, messages, account access and location data.
- Avoid blaming someone because they shared a photo, used an app or trusted a partner.
- The safest technical action depends on whether devices or accounts are being monitored.
- Support must be survivor-centred, age-appropriate and mindful of reporting/confidentiality limits.
- Schools, employers and technology platforms share responsibility for prevention and response.

References and evidence notes

1. UN Women (2025). FAQs on digital abuse, trolling, stalking and other forms of technology-facilitated violence. https://unwomen.org.au/faqs-trolling-stalking-doxing-and-other-forms-of-violence-against-women-in-the-digital-age/

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3. UN Women (2025). Strategy: Preventing and eliminating technology-facilitated violence against women and girls. https://unwomen.org.au/publications-and-resources/un-women-strategy-preventing-and-eliminating-technology-facilitated-violence-against-women-and-girls/

4. UNFPA. Making All Spaces Safe; SHIELD risk-aware technology-safety approach. https://www.unfpa.org/making-all-spaces-safe-global-programme-address-technology-facilitated-gender-based-violence

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8. UNFPA (2025). Resource compendium on technology-facilitated GBV. https://www.unfpa.org/resources/unfpa-resource-compendium-technology-facilitated-gender-based-violence

Publication quality checklist

- GBV and safeguarding professional review, including child-specific language.
- Digital safety review and local referral validation; do not present technology instructions as universal.
- Rwanda legal and reporting obligations reviewed by qualified local personnel.
- Kinyarwanda and French translation and local cultural review.
- Accessible reading level, screen-reader PDF quality, and updated references checked.